A teaspoon of saffron is all that's required for this soup, as its flavor is overpowering if used in greater quantity. Also, it's the most expensive spice in the world.

saffron soup

SERVES 4 **PREP** 15 MINS **COOK** 20 MINS **FREEZE** UP TO 3 MONTHS
WITHOUT CREAM AND LEMON JUICE

1 tbsp olive oil
1 large onion, sliced
7oz (200g) leeks, cut into 1in (2.5cm) lengths
5½oz (150g) potatoes, diced
1 tsp saffron
1 tsp ground cumin
1 quart (1 liter) hot chicken stock
salt and freshly ground black pepper
2 tbsp dry white wine
2 tbsp heavy cream
1 tbsp lemon juice
snipped chives, to garnish

1 Heat the oil in a heavy-based pan and cook the onion for 6–8 minutes or until soft. Add the leeks, potatoes, saffron, cumin, and stock, then season with salt and freshly ground black pepper. Cover with a lid and bring to a boil, then lower the heat and simmer for 10 minutes or until the potatoes are tender. Do not let them disintegrate into the soup.

2 Transfer to a blender, add the wine, and process until smooth. Stir in the cream and lemon juice and season again with salt and freshly ground black pepper. If the soup is too thick, dilute it with more stock or water. If it is too thin, add more olive oil. Garnish with the snipped chives and serve at once.